



Playoff glow: Colour, noise and a little distraction from looming reporting deadlines as fireworks burst over the HPCA Stadium. PTI

When the lights stole the show

Twelve months after the first attempt to cover an IPL game against the backdrop of the Himalayas came to an abrupt end because of a “technical failure”, the Diary set forth again for Qualifier 1 of IPL 2026.

A cancelled flight, a stadium evacuation, a trot through narrow lanes and finally an overcrowded bus ride back; the previous trip to Dharamsala was little more than a blur. This time, the hilly town offered a warm welcome, both in hospitality and temperature.

Time seemed to move much slower than amid the frenetic pace of the previous season, allowing the Diary a quick glimpse of Tibetan culture and the tourism boom in the McLeodganj area.

Dharamsala has been on the IPL calendar continuously since 2023, but was hosting a Playoff game for the

first time. The traditional red of the adopted home team, Punjab Kings, was replaced by the gleaming red and black of Royal Challengers Bengaluru. (No points for guessing whose name was on the back of those shirts!)

There were multiple shouts of ‘ahinya aav (come here)’ echoing through the bustling terrain that morning, but that did not really translate into support in the stands for Gujarat Titans. The disappointment of knowing that the snow-clad mountains sat behind the media centre was somewhat offset by the opportunity to walk along the boundary rope to reach the seating area. Once the match got underway, it was time for some intense finger-wiggling. Print scribes know the drill. The mid-innings break is not for a washroom visit or a hasty dinner; it is for getting the

first-innings report out of the way. But just as the finishing touches were being applied, off went the lights in the box (flashbacks!!). Only this time, it was for a grand laser light show.

The fans cheered as the lights rearranged themselves to display the badges of all participating teams in the league. The press box, however, was writhing with frustration for two reasons. First, the lights were programmed for the opposite end of the stadium. All the journalists could do was tilt their heads repeatedly to make sense of it, or watch it on television (which defeats the entire purpose of covering it from the stadium). Second, the print desk waits for no one, least of all an interminable entertainment spectacle. All thanks to the inventor of keyboard backlights for helping the Diary wade through this problem.

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